

Genshin DnD Session Guide

Sumeru Archon Quest — Act I: Through Mists of Smoke and Forests Dark

Arrival in Sumeru, the Akasha, Dunyarzad, Dehya, the Aranara Forest, and Forbidden Knowledge

Target Length: 3–4 hours

Session Tone: Vibrant and curious shifting to unsettling; wonder curdling into unease

Core Themes: Knowledge vs wisdom — Who decides what people should know — The cost of forbidden truth — Dreams vs reality

SESSION FLOW OVERVIEW

DM Note: Boxed text below can be read verbatim. Player choice branches are indented under each scene with clear consequences.

Act I (45–60 min): Arrival in Sumeru City Exploration, Akasha introduction, meeting Dunyarzad and Dehya

Act II (45–60 min): The Aranara Forest Forest encounter with Collei and Tighnari, combat

Act III (45–60 min): The Akademiya & Alhaithem Meeting Alhaithem, the Forbidden Knowledge capsule, the NPC's death

Act IV (20–30 min): Aftermath & Session Close Processing, hooks for next session

ACT I — ARRIVAL IN SUMERU

Scene 1: The Border Crossing (Opening RP)

Purpose: Establish Sumeru's identity as radically different from Liyue

READ ALOUD:

The stone roads of Liyue give way to packed earth, and then to something softer. The air changes first — heavier, wetter, thick with the smell of rain-soaked bark and unfamiliar spices. Then the trees close in overhead, and the sky narrows to ribbons of green-filtered light.

Sumeru does not announce itself with gates or banners. It simply swallows you. The forest is enormous — not just tall but deep, layered, alive in a way that feels deliberate. Mushrooms the size of wagons cling to trunks. Flowers pulse faintly with Dendro energy. Something chittered above you and went silent.

Ahead, where the canopy finally breaks, you see the city built into the cliff face — white stone and arched windows rising in tiers, with a vast tree crowning the summit. Sumeru City. And hovering at its heart, visible even from here, a faint lattice of

emerald light: the Akasha.

Scene 2: Sumeru City — First Impressions

Purpose: Establish the knowledge-obsessed culture and the Akasha's omnipresence

READ ALOUD:

The city hums with conversation, but it's a strange kind. Half the people you pass are speaking to no one — or rather, speaking to the air, eyes half-closed, fingers tracing invisible text. Terminals of pale green light float beside their heads like patient insects.

A merchant quotes you a price without looking up. A child recites botanical classifications while skipping. Two scholars argue viciously about a theorem, then stop simultaneously, consult their terminals, and walk away without resolving anything.

Knowledge here is not earned. It is dispensed.

DM Note: Let the players explore. Possible interactions: a street food vendor, a scholar arguing with a merchant, a child asking them what their Akasha terminals look like (they don't have them yet). This is a good place for 10–15 minutes of freeform RP.

Scene 3: Receiving the Akasha

Purpose: Give players the key item; establish its function and its limits

READ ALOUD:

A functionary at the Bureau of Registration — a thin woman with ink-stained fingers and an expression of practiced boredom — fits each of you with a small device that clips behind your ear. The moment it activates, the world... expands.

Not physically. But information layers itself over everything you see. The bridge you crossed: built 342 years ago, repaired twice. The fruit in the stall: Zaytun Peach, caloric content, optimal growing season. The scholar across the street: name, department, three published papers.

"Standard civilian access," the functionary says. "Restricted tiers require Akademiya clearance." She stamps a form without looking at you. "Welcome to Sumeru."

REVEAL 1 — The Akasha Is Not Neutral

When to Say It: When players first try to look something up

Information to Convey: The Akasha provides answers — but only approved answers. Certain queries return nothing. Asking about the Dendro Archon's current state returns: "The God of Wisdom watches over Sumeru." Asking about Forbidden Knowledge returns: "No results found."

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Accept it at face value:** Proceed normally; the cracks show later
- **Test its limits immediately:** They discover censorship early → Alhaithem notices them later (Act III advantage)
- **Refuse the device:** They can, but they'll be conspicuous — scholars treat them like illiterates

Scene 4: Meeting Dunyarzad

Purpose: Introduce the emotional anchor of the Sumeru arc

READ ALOUD:

You find her at a tea stall near the market square — a young woman with warm eyes and a voice that carries genuine delight at meeting strangers. She introduces herself as Dunyarzad, and she is immediately, disarmingly kind.

"You're travelers? Real ones? Not the kind who read about places and call it a journey?" She laughs, and it's bright but short — cut off by a cough she covers quickly with her sleeve. "Tell me everything. What does Liyue smell like? Is it true the harbor glows at night?"

Dunyarzad Portrayal:

- Genuinely curious — asks questions most Sumeru scholars wouldn't think to ask
- Warm, self-deprecating humor
- Occasionally pauses mid-sentence to catch her breath — don't explain why yet
- She dreams of attending the Sabzeruz Festival

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Share stories freely:** Dunyarzad remembers specific details later — becomes a trusted ally
- **Ask about her health:** She deflects: "Oh, it's nothing — the dry season." (She's lying.)
- **Brush her off:** She's gracious about it, but a later emotional beat loses impact

Scene 5: Dehya Appears

Purpose: Introduce the muscle; establish the Eremites and Sumeru's class tension

READ ALOUD:

The conversation is interrupted by a shadow falling across the table. A tall woman with sun-darkened skin, sharp amber eyes, and a claymore strapped across her back pulls up a chair without asking.

"You're the outsiders," she says. It's not a question. She glances at Dunyarzad with an expression that's half bodyguard, half older sister. "I'm Dehya. I keep her alive. Among other things."

She flags down the tea vendor. "The Akademiya doesn't care about people like Dunyarzad. The desert people — Eremites — we look after our own. The scholars can keep their theories."

Dehya Portrayal:

- Direct, practical, no patience for abstraction

- Protective of Dunyarzad — this is personal, not a contract
- Skeptical of the Akademiya but not hostile — resigned
- If pressed about her past: "I've worked for worse people for worse reasons."

REVEAL 2 — Sumeru's Two Worlds

When to Say It: During or after Dehya's introduction

Information to Convey: Sumeru is split — the Akademiya controls knowledge and governance from the city, while the desert Eremites live outside that system entirely. The Akasha doesn't work well in the desert. The scholars view the Eremites as uneducated. The Eremites view the scholars as useless.

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Side with Dehya's pragmatism:** She opens up more → combat advantage later (she fights harder alongside them)
- **Defend the Akademiya:** Dehya shrugs: "Give it a week." She's not offended, just tired of the argument
- **Ask about Dunyarzad's illness:** Dehya's expression hardens: "Not here." → private conversation later if pursued

ACT II — THE ARANARA FOREST

Scene 1: Into the Rainforest

Purpose: Transition from city to wilderness; build tension before combat

READ ALOUD:

Dehya leads you out of the city along a trail that stops being a trail within minutes. The forest closes in — not threatening, exactly, but insistent. Every surface is alive. Moss crawls. Roots shift underfoot. The Akasha terminals flicker and dim the deeper you go.

"The forest doesn't like being catalogued," Dehya says, pushing aside a vine. "Scholars have been mapping this place for centuries. The map is never right."

You hear something ahead — not an animal. A rhythmic thwack of wood striking wood, and between the hits, a girl's voice counting under her breath.

Scene 2: Collei — The Girl in the Clearing

Purpose: Introduce Collei; establish her as sympathetic before the fight

READ ALOUD:

In a clearing ringed by massive ferns, a young girl with green hair tied back in a messy braid is practicing with a bow. Her form is technically wrong — elbow too high, stance too narrow — but every arrow hits the target. She compensates through sheer stubbornness.

She sees you and freezes. The bow comes up — not aimed, but ready. Her eyes are wide. Not hostile. Scared.

"Who sent you?" she asks. Her voice is tight. "If the Akademiya sent you, I'm not going back."

Collei Portrayal:

- Anxious, defensive, expects the worst from strangers
- Fiercely independent despite obvious loneliness
- If the players are gentle, she lowers the bow quickly — she wants to trust people
- She has a Dendro vision but uses it clumsily — self-taught

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Identify as travelers (honest):** She relaxes slightly → Tighnari arrives calmly
- **Claim Akademiya affiliation:** She bolts → Tighnari arrives hostile, combat starts immediately
- **Approach slowly, hands visible:** She talks first → can learn her backstory before combat

Scene 3: Tighnari — The Forest Watcher

Purpose: Introduce Tighnari; set up the combat encounter

READ ALOUD:

A voice comes from above — measured, precise, and thoroughly unimpressed.

"You're standing in a restricted ecological zone," says the figure dropping from the canopy. Fennec-fox ears. Sharp green eyes. A bow already in hand, though not drawn. "I've been tracking you since the second ridge."

He lands beside Collei and puts a hand on her shoulder without looking at her. She steadies immediately.

"Tighnari. Forest Watcher. And you have about thirty seconds to explain why you're here before I decide you're poachers."

Tighnari Portrayal:

- Dry, blunt, lectures instinctively
- Protective of Collei and the forest in equal measure
- Respects competence — if players demonstrate knowledge of Nature/Dendro, he warms up
- Will fight if he thinks the forest is threatened, even if the players mean no harm

Scene 4: Combat — Forest Misunderstanding

Purpose: Combat encounter driven by miscommunication, not malice

DM Note: This fight should feel like a test, not a death match. Tighnari and Collei fight to subdue, not kill. If any player drops below 25% HP, Tighnari calls a ceasefire. The goal is to earn their respect through combat competence.

COMBAT TRIGGER: Any of: players fail to explain themselves, Collei panics and fires first, or the party accidentally damages the forest (trampling a Dendro-sensitive plant, etc.)

Enemies:

- **Tighnari** — Ranged (Bow). Uses Dendro-infused shots. Creates vine snare zones (2-tile radius, Root on entry). Prioritizes players who damage the environment. Retreats to range after each attack.
- **Collei** — Ranged (Bow). Less damage but applies Dendro to targets. Her boomerang ability hits in a line (3 tiles). She panics if flanked — Tighnari repositions to protect her.

ENVIRONMENT:

- Dense canopy: ranged attacks beyond 8 tiles have disadvantage
- Dendro plants: if hit by a stray attack, release spore clouds (apply Nature element in 2-tile radius)
- Elevated roots: provide half cover, cost +1 movement to cross

END CONDITION: Combat ends when either side is reduced to 50% HP total, OR a player explicitly calls for a truce (requires giving up their action for the turn).

PLAYER CHOICES DURING COMBAT:

- **Focus Collei:** Tighnari becomes aggressive — harder fight but faster
- **Focus Tighnari:** Collei panics and fights recklessly, occasionally hitting herself with friendly fire
- **Call for truce (costs action):** Tighnari stops immediately if the player makes a convincing case (no roll needed if they reference protecting the forest or mention Dunyarzad/Dehya)
- **Deliberately avoid killing blows:** Tighnari notices → post-combat respect bonus

Scene 5: Post-Combat — Earned Trust

Purpose: Resolve tension; transition to Act III

READ ALOUD (after ceasefire):

Tighnari lowers his bow and sighs — not with relief, but with the specific exhaustion of someone who is tired of being right about people.

"Fine," he says. "You're not poachers. You fight like people with actual problems." He looks at Collei. "Get the salve."

While Collei patches up the worst of it — muttering apologies the whole time — Tighnari studies your group. "If you're heading deeper into Sumeru's business, you'll need someone who actually understands how this nation works. Not the Akademiya version. The real version."

He pauses. "There's a man in the city. Alhaithem. He's insufferable. He's also the smartest person I've ever met. Find him before the Akademiya finds you."

ACT III — THE AKADEMIYA & ALHAITHEM

Scene 1: Finding Alhaithem

Purpose: Introduce the key intellectual ally of the Sumeru arc

READ ALOUD:

You find him in the least scholarly place imaginable — a wine stall near the lower markets, reading a book while ignoring the drink in front of him. He is tall, silver-haired, and radiates the particular arrogance of someone who has never been proven wrong and resents the lack of challenge.

He looks up before you speak. "Tighnari sent you." Again — not a question. "Sit down. Don't touch my drink. And don't ask me what I think about the Akademiya unless you have three hours and a tolerance for being condescended to."

Alhaithem Portrayal:

- Brilliant and fully aware of it — not cruel, just uninterested in pretending otherwise
- Speaks in complete, precise sentences — never wastes a word
- Dislikes the Akademiya not because it's corrupt but because it's mediocre
- Will help, but only because the problem is interesting — not because he cares (he does care, but will never admit it)

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Match his energy (confident):** He respects it — shares information freely
- **Defer to his expertise:** He's polite but bored — gives less detail
- **Challenge him intellectually:** He lights up — this is the best outcome; he treats them as equals

Scene 2: The Forbidden Knowledge Capsule

Purpose: Introduce the central threat of the Sumeru arc

READ ALOUD:

"The Akademiya hoards knowledge," Alhaithem says, setting his book down. "That is expected. What is less expected is what they're hiding from themselves."

He produces a small object from his coat — a dark capsule, no larger than an egg, that seems to drink the light around it. Looking at it too long makes your eyes water. The Akasha terminal behind your ear buzzes — not with information, but with static.

"This was recovered from a sealed vault beneath the Akademiya. Officially, it doesn't exist. Unofficially, there are six more. They call it Forbidden Knowledge — which is a remarkably honest name, for once."

REVEAL 3 — What Forbidden Knowledge Is

When to Say It: When players ask what it does

Information to Convey: Forbidden Knowledge is not just censored information — it is knowledge that is inherently destructive. It corrodes the mind of anyone who absorbs it. The Akasha was designed, in part, to filter it out. The Dendro Archon — Lesser Lord Kusanali — has been containing it for centuries, at enormous personal cost. The Akademiya knows. They use her sacrifice as infrastructure and call it governance.

Scene 3: The Theft — "I Can Handle It"

Purpose: Demonstrate the lethality of Forbidden Knowledge through an NPC death

DM Note: This scene should feel sudden and irreversible. The NPC acts before anyone can stop them. Do not give the players a chance to prevent it — the point is that knowledge itself can be the weapon.

READ ALOUD:

The scholar appears from the crowd — young, eager, a junior researcher who's been following your group since the market. He moves fast. One hand snatches the capsule from the table. Alhaithem reaches for it but the man is already backing away.

"You don't understand," the scholar says, voice shaking with excitement, not fear. "This is what the sages have been hiding. If I can publish this — if people can see what the Akademiya keeps from them—"

He cracks the capsule open.

READ ALOUD (the death):

The light that escapes is not light. It is the absence of something — a void that presses against your thoughts like fingers pushing through wet paper. The scholar's expression shifts from triumph to confusion to recognition to horror in the space of a single breath.

His Akasha terminal shatters. Black veins crawl up his neck, across his jaw, into his eyes. He opens his mouth to scream but what comes out is information — raw, unfiltered, meaningless data pouring from his lips in languages that don't exist, equations that contradict themselves, histories of places that were never built.

It lasts four seconds. Then he drops. The silence afterward is total.

Alhaithem kneels beside the body. His expression hasn't changed, but his hand trembles when he closes the dead man's eyes.

"That," he says quietly, "is what they're protecting you from. That is also why they cannot be trusted to decide what you should know."

PLAYER CHOICES:

- **Blame Alhaithem for having the capsule:** He accepts the criticism without flinching: "You're right. And I'd do it again, because someone has to understand it."
- **Try to help the scholar (healing):** Nothing works. The damage is not physical — his mind was overwritten.
- **Demand answers about the Dendro Archon:** Alhaithem pauses. "She's the one holding all of this back. Alone. And the sages have her locked in a sanctuary they call a prison."

- **Want to destroy the remaining capsules:** Alhaithem: "Destroying them might be worse. We don't know what happens when Forbidden Knowledge is released without a vessel."

ACT IV — AFTERMATH & SESSION CLOSE

Scene 1: Processing

Purpose: Give players space to react; set hooks

READ ALOUD:

The Millelith equivalent — Sumeru's Matra — arrive within minutes. The body is covered. Questions are asked. Alhaithem answers them with practiced ease, omitting everything that matters. The capsule fragments are gone — you didn't see him collect them, but they're gone.

Dehya finds you as the crowd disperses. She looks at your faces and doesn't ask what happened.

"Come on," she says. "Dunyarzad's been asking about you. And you all look like you need tea more than answers right now."

Scene 2: Quiet Close — Dunyarzad's Roof

Purpose: End on a human note after the horror

READ ALOUD:

Dunyarzad's home is small and warm and smells like cardamom. She serves tea without asking if you want any. From her roof, you can see the Akademiya glowing above the city — beautiful, distant, and now something else entirely.

"The Sabzeruz Festival is in three days," Dunyarzad says, looking at the lights. "Whatever you're carrying — whatever happened today — it can wait until morning." She coughs, smiles, and adds: "I've been waiting my whole life to see the festival. A few more hours won't hurt."

Epilogue — Threads for Next Session

- The Dendro Archon is imprisoned — by the people who worship her
- Forbidden Knowledge capsules remain in Akademiya vaults
- Alhaithem is an ally of convenience, not trust
- Collei and Tighnari guard the forest — and whatever the forest is hiding
- Dunyarzad's illness is unnamed and worsening
- The Sabzeruz Festival approaches — a perfect setting for the next session's inciting incident

End the session with warmth masking dread. The tea is good. The city is beautiful. Something underneath it is very, very wrong.